7.16 The Church of St Nicholas and the Romanesque Cellar, Gdańsk, Poland

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Location and surroundings

The relics of the oldest monumental architecture in Gdańsk are located in the heart of the city's historic centre. The masonry Romanesque St Nicholas Church are exhibited in situ inside the historic Market Hall which is owned by a private company. The Romanesque Cellar, part of the 13th-century monastery, is presented nearby, beneath Dominikański Square, between the gothic church of St Nicholas (Fig.80) and the Market Hall. This is the area of the so-called Dominican Hillock (Kępa Dominikańska), a slight land elevation in the north-western part of historic Main Town (Fig.79).

Gdańsk is one of Poland's oldest cities of great historical importance. The first mention of Gdańsk dates back to 997 AD and comes from the life of St Adalbert. In the 13th century Gdańsk was granted a city charter modelled on Lübeck law. The next stage in its history was the period of occupation by the Teutonic Order. This resulted in the granting of a new privilege for the Main Town under the Chełmno law. In 1361 Gdańsk, a port city of growing importance, became a member of the Hanseatic League, which allowed it to engage in maritime trade on favourable terms. After the victorious war with the Teutonic Knights, it was incorporated into Poland in 1454. This was a golden period in Gdańsk's history, both economically – as a major trading port, prospering from the export of grain, salt and timber floated down the Vistula from all over the Commonwealth – and culturally – as a city open to foreigners, attracting artists and craftsmen from other European centres, who found wealthy patrons among Gdańsk's burghers. Late Gothic brick churches, townhouses, military buildings and modern structures by prominent Northern European architects, who gave the city its distinctive image, account for its exceptional artistic qualities. Only a few cities in northern Europe have retained so much of their pre-18th century urban structure. Thus, Gdańsk today is a showcase of late and post-medieval urban heritage. It is also one of the most valuable architectural and urban ensembles in Poland. An estimated 3 million tourists visit Gdańsk every year.

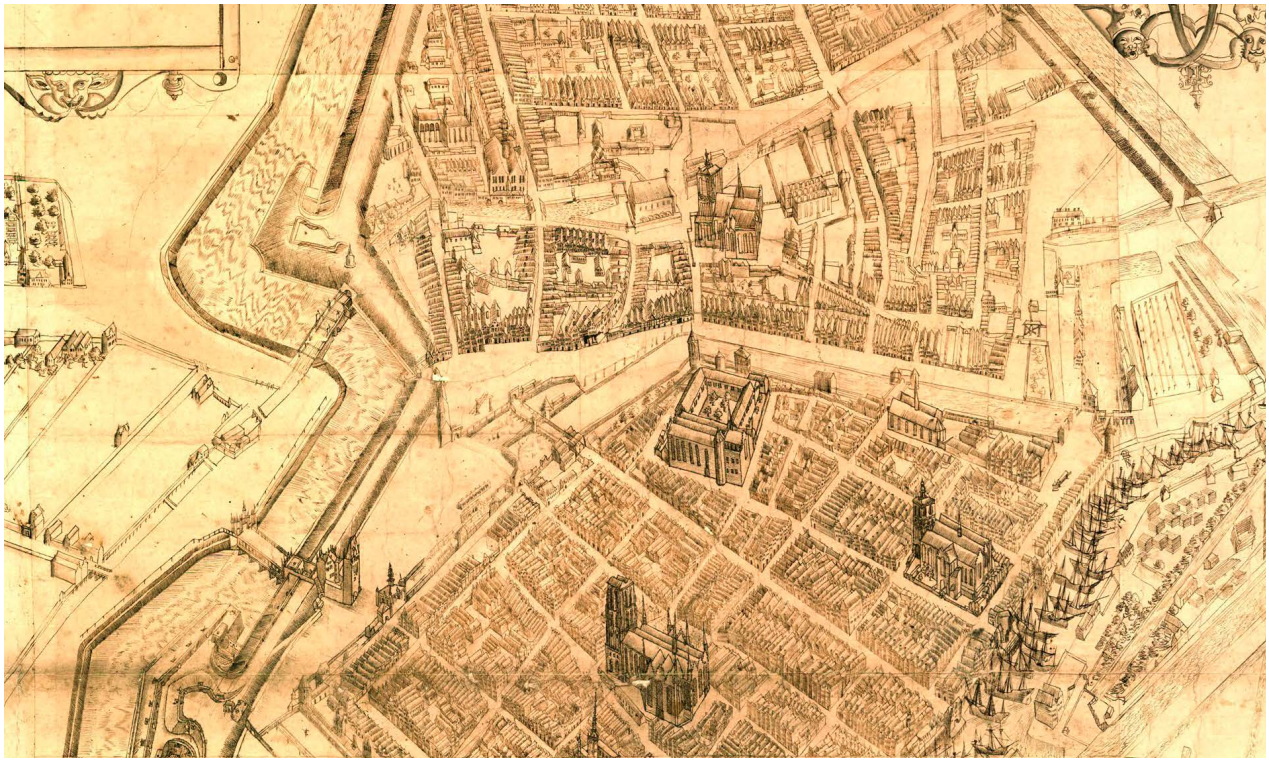

Figure 79: Fragment of the plan of the city of Gdansk from 1615, with the St Nicholas Church and Dominican monastery in the centre. (Source: electronic collection of the National Archives of Sweden (Riksarkivet) - riksarkivet.se, Reference code: SE/KrA/0406/25/044/013)

Figure 80: St Nicholas Church, as it stands today. (National Institute of Cultural Heritage, Agnieszka Makowska)

Reasons for assessment

The need to assess the significance of the relics came with their discovery. They were discovered during rescue excavations conducted by the Archaeological Museum in Gdańsk. The first archaeological works carried out in the area were related to the renovation of the Market Hall and the lowering of its basement to create additional retail space. The research began in 2001. The biggest, most sensational discovery was the foundations of the nave and the choir, with an apse of St Nicholas Church (Fig.80). An investment was underway, so an assessment of the value of the artefacts uncovered was needed to make decisions about the future of the site. The same goes for the remains of the first Dominican cloister. The excavations that led to the discovery of the Romanesque Cellar initially were carried out as part of the renovation of Dominican Square, which is now an area of an open-air market. Significance assessment was an essential part of the decision-making process for the relics found.

Description of the site

The construction of the masonry Romanesque Church began, most probably, at the end of the 12th century. Physical and chemical tests showed that the first church was erected around the year 1190. As a result of excavations, the plan of the oldest church was defined. It had a single nave made of stone, two towers made of brick from the west and the apse from the east. According to the researchers from the Archaeological Museum in Gdańsk, the entrance was between the towers. The church was 34.5 m long. It was founded on the site of a cemetery, which was still in use at the time the church was built.

Archaeologists found that some parts of the building had collapsed in a fire at the beginning of the 13th century. At the end of January 1227, the Duke of Gdańsk, Świętopełk, handed over St Nicolas' church to the Dominicans, who had just arrived in the city. They have been part of the city's history ever since, often at the centre of events. The Dominicans rebuilt the church according to the Latin cross plan using salvaged materials. The buildings of their monastery from this period were erected to the south of the church, on the border of the town housing.

Figure 81: Inside the historic Market Hall, with relics of the Romanesque church on the ground floor. (National Institute of Cultural Heritage, Agnieszka Makowska)

In 1308 Gdańsk was attacked by the Teutonic Knights. The town was in flames. That was also when the monastery and once again the church burned down. The church was then rebuilt a short distance away to the south, where it stands today. On the ruins of the destroyed monastery as well as in place of the former church, a new Gothic monastery was founded. There were more and more monks living within the walls, and intellectual life and preaching flourished. The monastery survived almost unchanged until the Napoleonic army entered Gdańsk in 1807. It was then converted into a large field hospital, and continued to be used this way until its destruction by the Russian army in 1813. In 1896, a Market Hall was built on the site of the destroyed monastery. Registered as a monument, the Market Hall still performs its original function.

The church's stone foundations, partly open to the public after conservation work, are now to be found under the Market Hall (Figs.82 & 83). These are displayed on the lowest floor of the hall. The exhibition, in the form of an underground archaeological museum which includes the remnants of the church's chancel and parts of the nave, can also be seen from the level of the two upper floors of the building, the ground floor and the mezzanine level, as a free space has been designed above the relics. It is surrounded by a glass fence. There are food stalls all around it, frequented by local people who can come into contact with the heritage as they go about their daily shopping. The excavation, conservation and exhibition were fully funded by the owner of the Market Hall, the Dominican Merchant Company. The hall is currently being renovated by its new owner. It is being converted into a three-level food hall, meeting place and concert venue. Relics from the church will still be on exhibit.

The Romanesque Cellar is the only surviving late Romanesque brick building in Gdańsk (Fig.83). It is the remains of a hall from the 13th century with a vaulted ceiling supported by a single pillar. It is well preserved, at 60 per cent, including important parts of the unique vault. According to the researchers, its floor was originally about 1.2 metres below the level of the ground at that time. The room served as a refectory of the first Dominican monastery. A kitchen with a brick oven attached to the refectory, the staircase leading to the refectory floor and an entrance from the south